network of supporters—samurai, fishermen, and pirates—who wanted to be rid of Hojo Takatoki's rule. In the winter of 1333, a small band of pirates and fishermen helped Go-Daigo escape from his island. He landed on the shores of Hoki Province and found an army there already assembled, waiting for his leadership.[11]

At the news, Hojo Takatoki dispatched his own army from Kamakura, led by Ashikaga Takauji and another commander. Nitta Yoshisada, also a descendant of the Minamoto clan. But Ashikaga Takauji felt that the *shikken* had been slow in rewarding his loyalty; contemplating a change in allegiance, he had been carrying on a secret correspondence with Go-Daigo for the last year. Once out of Kamakura, he swapped sides, followed closely by Nitta Yoshisada and most of the army. Together, the men led a two-pronged attack against Hojo power; Ashikaga Takauji took part of the force into Kyoto and drove out the Hojo officials there, while Nitta Yoshisada led the rest directly against Kamakura.[12]

Both attacks succeeded. Emperor Kogon and the military governor of Kyoto fled together to the east but were quickly overtaken; the governor was killed on the spot, Kogon brought back to Kyoto and imprisoned. Nitta Yoshisada and his men fought a five-day battle at Kamakura against the Hojo supporters. Driven steadily back, facing almost certain defeat, the Hojo generals and officials began to commit suicide, one after another. On July 5, 1333, Hojo Takatoki retreated with three hundred supporters to the Kamakura temple where his ancestors were buried. "Kill yourselves quickly!" he shouted to them. "I'll go first to set the example!" He swigged down a bowl of wine, passed it to his closest companion, and then "plunged his dagger into his left side, cut a long gash extending all the way to his right flank, pulled out his guts, and fell prostrate." Nitta Yoshisada's men were already setting fire to the temple, and Takatoki's men followed him; the *Taiheiki* says that nearly eight hundred men killed themselves on that single day.[13]

Go-Daigo returned to Kyoto, claiming that he had never actually abdicated and ignoring Kogon's brief stint on the throne entirely. In the next three years, known as the Kemmu Restoration, he attempted to take back direct rule of the country, as though the intervening exile had never happened. But Ashikaga Takauji was simultaneously angling for the vacant position of *shikken*. He had already set himself up in the emptied shogunate offices of Kyoto, and from there he appointed military governors just as the Hojo *shikken* had done. In 1335, he moved himself to Kamakura and began to give out grants of land.

He still had not claimed for himself the title of either *shikken* or shogun. But Go-Daigo had intended to free himself from the dictates of the shogunate,